myth, so also is the idea that the arc of history bends toward justice. History is a radically open arc, one that can bend in many directions and reach very different destinations. Even if *Homo sapiens* destroys itself, the universe will keep going about its business as usual. It took four billion years for terrestrial evolution to produce a civilisation of highly intelligent apes. If we are gone, and it takes evolution another hundred million years to produce a civilisation of highly intelligent rats, it will. The universe is patient.

There is, though, an even worse scenario. As far as we know today, apes, rats and the other organic animals of planet Earth may be the only conscious entities in the entire universe. We have now created a non-conscious but very powerful alien intelligence. If we mishandle it, AI might extinguish not only the human dominion on earth but the light of consciousness itself, turning the universe into a realm of utter darkness. It is our responsibility to prevent this.

The good news is that if we eschew complacency and despair, we are capable of creating balanced information networks that will keep their own power in check. Doing so is not a matter of inventing another miracle technology or landing upon some brilliant idea that has somehow escaped all previous generations. Rather, to create wiser networks, we must abandon both the naive and the populist views of information, put aside our fantasies of infallibility and commit ourselves to the hard and rather mundane work of building institutions with strong self-correcting mechanisms. That is perhaps the most important takeaway this book has to offer.

This wisdom is much older than human history. It is elemental, the foundation of organic life. The first organisms weren’t created by some infallible genius or god. They emerged through an intricate process of trial and error. Over four billion years, ever more complex mechanisms of mutation and self-correction led to the evolution of trees, dinosaurs, jungles and eventually humans. Now we have summoned an alien inorganic intelligence that could escape our control and put in danger not just our own species but countless other life-forms. The decisions we all make in the coming years will determine whether summoning this alien intelligence proves to be a terminal error or the beginning of a hopeful new chapter in the evolution of life.